

Dr Weliton Menário Costa (Dr WELI)

Scientist-artist · Creative innovator · Founder, WildWooHoo

Sydney, Australia · weli@drweli.com · drweli.com · wildwoohoo.com · +61 420 251 952 Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (intermediate) Work eligibility: Australian Permanent Resident · Italian (EU) citizen · Brazilian citizen · NSW Working with Children Check (WWC2779967E, to 01/12/2028)

Creative-innovator master CV (artistic practice, studio, coined terms, forthcoming publications, appearances). Companion to the academic/ATS master CV. Comprehensive source; trim per opportunity. Truth-of-case: forthcoming work is marked as such; award is always “AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024”.

Profile

I am a scientist-artist and creative innovator who turns complex ideas into creative experiences, joining behavioural-ecology research (PhD, ANU) with music, film, performance and public programs so that science lands with audiences of every age. My research-creation project *Kangaroo Time* was the AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024, and through my studio, WildWooHoo, I now design keynotes, workshops, performances, educational programs and original creative productions, and I write on science in popular culture as a Visiting Fellow at ANU’s Centre for the Public Awareness of Science. My work runs in English and Portuguese, and reaches corporate, university, school, festival and public audiences across Australia, Brazil, Europe, the United Kingdom and the United States.

Signature contributions and coined terms

- **“Complex ideas into creative experiences”**: my positioning and practice, sourcing from research, reports and strategy and giving ideas a form audiences remember (music, film, performance, programs).
 - **“Sci pop”**: a genre term I coined for popular songs that carry science as aesthetic, theme or method, ranging from real research to the fictional cultural imaginary; what makes a song sci pop is intention, sourcing from science and bringing scientific thinking into the songwriting and production (founding text published on Zenodo, 2026: doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21387516).
 - **The five-step live-experience method**: every energiser, workshop, keynote or performance runs the same five steps: (1) Start together, in movement (open with collective movement, out of static, before any idea; the real difference); (2) Bring in the idea (introduce the finding or concept and find its human angle); (3) Translate it (carry the idea into music, movement, story or image so people feel it); (4) Make it together (people take part and make something with the idea); (5) Leave one clear thing (a single idea they keep and can act on).
 - **Principles**: participation and co-creation · inclusion and access · culture and belonging · emotion and wonder · translation and language.
 - **The Interconnected Narrative method**: my making method for composing science-sourced artwork (practice-based; see Research and writing).
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Selected creative and artistic production

- **Kangaroo Time** (2024): research-creation song, film and dance work connecting behavioural-ecology research with music and dance; peer-reviewed science turned into a pop song and a dance cast drawn from multicultural Canberra. AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024. Kids edit: youtube.com/watch?v=ZUZkLnTioLQ · Dance Your PhD edit: youtube.com/watch?v=RoSYO3fApEc
- **Cabra da Peste (G.O.A.T.)** (2024): original song (Latin pop), commissioned for and performed at the opening plenary of the Encontro Anual de Etologia (Brazil), plenary theme “Creativity and Science unifying communities”; co-written and performed with Jon Panic (Black Bird Hum).

- **Yours Academically, Dr. WELI** (EP): released; science, queer and Latin-immigrant narratives across reggaeton, electronic and Brazilian funk.
- **EVER+GROW**: first sci pop album by WELI, in development (recording December 2026, launch Q2 2027); Phase-1 EP *Benevolence*.
- **Kanga-Kangaroo**: animated series, in development.
- **Children's field-guide booklet line**: science booklets for young readers, in development (launch planned 2027).
- **The Photography Project**: ongoing; imagery featuring people, animals and shared landscapes.
- **KT Kids (Kangaroo Time Kids)**: schools program translating the research into science, music and movement for students.
- **Sync catalogue**: cleared catalogue for television, film, documentary, advertising and brand work; international sync placements across three broadcasters (2024).
- **WELI (recording and performing artist; songwriter)**: original music celebrating science, drawing on Latin, Brazilian and Afro influences; songwriter across the sci pop catalogue, with production delivered through studio producers and collaborators; APRA AMCOS writer member since 2023; released and streamable catalogue (drweli.com/music).

Broader performance, dance and screen - Brazilian dance and dance fitness: led guided dance-fitness classes and Brazilian-hits choreography with Só Samba Canberra and Rio Samba Shows (2022–2024), including teaching at Blank (2023); continues to perform Brazilian carnival sets with the crew at ACT festivals. Dance-fitness training (2021). - **Screen and modelling**: screen extra, including *Young Rock* (Gold Coast, 2021, via 888 Agency); photographic modelling (Victoria Models, 2020).

WildWooHoo — creative innovation studio (Founder & Creative Director, 2026 to present; creative-innovation practice since 2024)

WildWooHoo takes complex ideas from research papers, reports and strategy documents and turns them into creative experiences: the music, films and books we make, and the keynotes, workshops and performances we bring to a room. See the work at wildwoohoo.com/work and the approach at wildwoohoo.com/method.

What I deliver (four formats plus a partnership): - **Keynotes**: talks that make science and ideas move a room. - **Workshops**: hands-on sessions that turn research into creative, memorable learning for teams, students and HDR researchers. - **Consultancy**: evidence-informed public engagement, communication and program design. - **Creative productions**: commissioned music, film and educational materials. - **Creative Research Engagement Partnership**: a 6 to 12 month retainer with one organisation at a time.

Programs by audience (drweli.com/program): Corporate (conference keynotes, team workshops, creative-thinking activations) · Universities (research translation, student engagement) · Schools (STEAM incursions in science, music and movement) · Science × Art (original collaborative projects).

Keynotes, performance and public programming

Selected appearances - **Opening plenary** (with commissioned performance of *Cabra da Peste*), Encontro Anual de Etologia, Brazil, 2024. - **Floriade**, Canberra, 2025. - **Three Minute Thesis (3MT) half-time show**, Llewellyn Hall, ANU, 2024. - **ACT National Science Week**, 2024 and 2025 (with Inspiring Australia ACT). - **ANU HDR Research Festival**. - **Athens Science Festival (Athens Sci-Co)**. - **Guest lecture**, ANU Centre for the Public Awareness of Science. - **ANU Commencement**, 2025 — co-master of ceremonies. - **Resilience Workshop** — closing keynote. - **Falling Walls Engage 2025: one of 30 shortlisted worldwide**, for “Science and the People”.

Engagement formats: keynotes and conference energisers · science-art residencies and commissions · festival and community engagement · university and Dance Your PhD workshops · the Kangaroo Time Kids classroom program. For corporate, university, school, festival and public audiences across Australia, Brazil, Europe, the United Kingdom and the United States. Full engagement record: wildwoohoo.com/engagement.

Research

I run three strands of research, and my artistic practice sits inside them: peer-reviewed science underneath, current academic research into how science lives in popular culture, and creative research that feeds directly into what I make. The making and the studying happen together. This is what makes the practice scientist-artist: the science background and the artistry working as one body of work.

Scientific research — behavioural ecology - Menário Costa, W., King, W. J., Bonnet, T., Festa-Bianchet, M., & Kruuk, L. E. B. (2023). Early-life behavior, survival, and maternal personality in a wild marsupial. *Behavioral Ecology*, 34(6), 1002–1012. (drweli.com/academic) - Doctoral thesis: Menário Costa, W. (2021). *Personality, social environment, and maternal-level effects: insights from a wild kangaroo population*. The Australian National University. Supervisors: Prof. Loeske Kruuk (ANU) and Prof. Marco Festa-Bianchet (Université de Sherbrooke).

Academic research (current) — science communication and science in popular culture Visiting Fellow, ANU Centre for the Public Awareness of Science (Popsicule); fellowship oversight Prof. Sujatha Raman. Line: “Science in Music and Pop Culture”. - *Principles of effective engagement with music in/for science communication* — with Anna-Sophie Jürgens, Graham Walker and Gypsy Cook (ANU CPAS). In preparation. Sets out principles across narrative (story in a song or series of songs), multimodality (visual and physical), inclusion and access, participation, and the outcomes of music, with *Kangaroo Time* as a worked case. - *Ack! Ack! Ack! — Aliens, Camp Science and Science Communication in Film* — book chapter with Anna-Sophie Jürgens, Karina Judd and Anastasiya Fiadotava; proposes the concept of “camp science” through science-fiction cinema (*Santa Claus 1959*, *Mars Attacks!* 1996, *Men in Black II* 2002). In review, chapter in the Routledge volume *Humour and Science Communication*.

Creative research (independent, through WildWooHoo) The one strand I run independently through the studio: research that feeds my practice directly. - Menário Costa, W. (2026). *Sci pop: science as aesthetic, theme and method in contemporary popular music* (Version v1). Zenodo. doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21387516. Founding text coining and defining the term. - *The Interconnected Narrative method* — artistic-research article on the science-to-artwork composition method I use to build science-sourced work — in preparation.

Research interests (future directions) Forward interests sit at the intersection of comparative cognition, cultural cognition and cultural musicology — what a Dr WELI × WildWooHoo lab would explore: - Human-animal cognition and social-system parallels (behavioural-ecology constructs read across species as comparative biology, not anthropomorphism). - Cultural cognition and routine thinking (culturally transmitted thought templates about nature, evolution and the species we share the planet with). - Collective imaginaries and emotion in music and popular culture (cultural musicology). - The evolved brain in synthetic environments (evolutionary mismatch; attention, mental health, child neurodevelopment).

Source: wildwoohoo.com/research-and-educational/; full research profile at drweli.com/academic.

(Forthcoming titles are working titles; collaborators named above; venues and dates confirmed where noted.)

Selected collaborations

- **Jon Panic** (Black Bird Hum): co-writer and performer, *Cabra da Peste*.
- **Nic Vevers** (ANU Science): production, *Kangaroo Time* video.
- **Nicholas Moynihan**: soundscape and composition.
- **Dr Anna-Sophie Jürgens** (ANU CPAS / Popsicule): research collaborator, science in popular culture.
- **Simon Clews** (HDR researcher-development advisor, ANU): HDR student development and the Three Minute Thesis half-time show (Llewellyn Hall, ANU, 2024).

Recognition and awards

- **AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner (2024)**, for *Kangaroo Time* (overall global top prize; AU\$4,000).
- **Falling Walls Engage 2025: one of 30 shortlisted worldwide**, for “Science and the People”.

Grants, scholarships and funding

- **Social Policy Group grant (2024):** AU\$20,000 (excl. GST), for CALD-inclusive events combining science and music.
 - **ACT National Science Week / Inspiring Australia ACT grant (2024):** AU\$1,700, for *Cabra da Peste*.
 - **Holsworth Wildlife Research Endowment (2017–2020):** field-research funding for the kangaroo PhD.
 - **ANU PhD Scholarship, International (2017–2020):** approx. AU\$26,288 per year.
 - **ANU HDR Fee Remission Merit Scholarship (2017–2021).**
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Media (selected)

238+ media features across five continents (approx. 15M+ potential reach; figures from own press archive; full coverage at drweli.com/media). Selected: The Guardian (“ANU scientist wins global science prize”, 27 Feb 2024) · Smithsonian (“A musical celebration of kangaroo behaviour”, 28 Feb 2024) · NPR (Morning Edition; All Things Considered, 5 Mar 2024) · Australian Geographic · O Globo (29 Feb 2024) · BBC · LGBTQ+ press (LGBT Nation).

Positions and affiliations

- **Visiting Fellow (Honorary)**, Centre for the Public Awareness of Science (Popsicule), ANU College of Systems & Society (2025 to 2027; renewed for a second term). Collaborator: Dr Anna-Sophie Jürgens.
 - **Founder & Creative Director**, WildWooHoo (2026 to present); creative-innovation practice since 2024.
 - **Research Data Scientist**, UNSW (2025 to 2026): student-experience and academic-quality analytics.
 - **University Tutor**, Research School of Biology, ANU (2019 to 2021): animal behaviour, ecology and statistical thinking.
 - **Queer Officer**, PARSA, ANU (2019 to 2020): LGBTQ+ inclusion events across science and the arts.
 - **artsACT Artist Database** (2026): listed as Dr WELI at arts.act.gov.au/artists/dr-weli, under Interdisciplinary, Music, Performance, Producer and Screen.
 - **AIR**, Australian Independent Record Labels Association (artist member, 2026); **APRA AMCOS** (writer member, 2023).
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Education and training

- **PhD, Ecology & Evolution**, The Australian National University (2017–2021). Supervisors: Prof. Loeske Kruuk and Prof. Marco Festa-Bianchet. Thesis: personality, social environment and maternal effects in wild kangaroos.
 - **Licenciatura and Bacharelado, Biological Sciences**, Instituto Federal do Espírito Santo (Ifes), Brazil, from 2010; with a Science Without Borders exchange at Griffith University, Australia (2013 to 2014).
 - **Voice and songwriting training**: four short courses in voice and songwriting at the Open Academy, Sydney Conservatorium of Music (University of Sydney), 2025–2026; plus private voice and performance coaching (ANU School of Music, NIDA short courses, Canberra vocal coaches).
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Capabilities

Creative direction · Science communication and research translation · Songwriting (production delivered through studio producers and collaborators) · Live performance · Film and audiovisual scripting and creative direction (videography and editing outsourced) · Workshop facilitation and program design · Keynote speaking · Bilingual delivery in English and Portuguese (with short sessions also in Spanish).